

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Mexican immigrant who sewed the official jersey retirement banners for Michael Jordan, Scottie Pippen and Derrick Rose ‘deserves the front seat now’



SHE HAS THEIR NUMBERS

By Laura Turbay | Chicago Tribune

When Maria Estela Parra saw herself on the Jumbotron at a Chicago Bulls game last month, hand-stitching Derrick Rose’s number retirement banner, she pointed to the screen stunned and said, “That’s me.”

Her granddaughter captured the Jan. 24 moment at the United Center on video and within hours, Parra — the 64-year-old Mexican seamstress responsible for many of Chicago’s most iconic sports banners — went viral.

It was a long way from when the mother of two — who didn’t know how to sew and knew even less about sports — came to Chicago looking for a job. Four decades later, and now a grandmother of eight, Parra has left her permanent mark on the tapestry of Chicago sports history — literally. She’s also hand-sewn the official number retirement banners for Michael Jordan and Scottie Pippen.

“A lot of times she’s taken the back seat,” said her granddaughter Paloma Padilla. “She deserves the front seat now.”

Parra began her career in 1986. She was around 24 and a young mother of two from Guadalajara, Mexico, who had come to the U.S. in search of a better life. Though she didn’t know how to sew, her sister-in-law helped find her a job at W.G.N. Flag and Decorating Co. as a seamstress.

She learned by watching others and taking on small tasks, such as stitching together a flag’s colors. Her hands, pricked by countless pins, have made sports history with banners for the Bulls, Blackhawks, Bears and White Sox.

“Virtually every banner in the United Center was handcrafted right here,” said Carl Porter,

Seamstress Maria Estela Parra displays an oversized Blackhawks banner she is working on at W.G.N. Flag and Decorating Co. in Chicago on Jan. 29. Parra has handcrafted banners and flags for Chicago’s leading sports teams for 40 years.

ANTONIO PEREZ/
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

president at W.G.N. Flag and Decorating Co. “Estela has had her hands in just about all of them, if not every single one.”

In turn, the small, family-owned flag and banner shop on South Chicago Avenue, which began in 1916, has become like a second home for Parra, she said.

On a typical day, Parra wakes up early from her home in the South Side to cook breakfast and prepare her family’s afternoon lunch before going to work at W.G.N., where she sews, stitches and trims from 8:30 a.m. to 4:30 p.m.

“I love it,” she said. She especially loves the design aspect. “It’s where you put all the detail in, all your effort.”

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ELECTION 2026 COMPTROLLER

Candidate’s lost investment puts cryptocurrency in center of race

By Jeremy Gorner
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — Months before Lake County Treasurer Holly Kim announced her bid for Illinois comptroller, she used about \$8,300 in previously contributed campaign funds to invest in a cryptocurrency she founded called CHKN token — a digital asset inspired by her backyard flock of chickens.

By the end of 2025, the investment — totaling roughly 8.87 million tokens — had lost nearly all its value, dropping to just \$34.59, according to filings with the Illinois State Board of Elections.

Kim, a Democrat seeking to succeed Comptroller Susana Mendoza as the state’s chief fiscal officer, said the loss should not be viewed as a reflection of her ability to oversee Illinois’ finances. Instead,



Holly Kim, a candidate for Illinois comptroller, attends a rally on Jan. 20 in Chicago’s Federal Plaza to support democracy on the anniversary of President Donald Trump’s inauguration.

BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

she described the investment as a learning experience that reflected her efforts to better understand emerging financial technologies.

“I’m someone who learns things by doing, and this is, you know, entirely why I would have converted crypto into a token,

because, you know, it depends what’s popular,” Kim said in an interview late last month with the Tribune about the investment. “But voters can absolutely trust me because I’m trying to stay on top and learn

Turn to Comptroller, Page 5

Ill. heeds doctors’ vaccine advice

State will follow pediatrics group’s schedule, shunning federal recommendations

By Lisa Schencker
Chicago Tribune

Illinois will adopt the childhood vaccine schedule recently released by the American Academy of Pediatrics, in a rejection of federal recommendations.

The move is the latest example of Illinois breaking with the federal government over health care policies and guidance since President Donald Trump took office. The Trump administration has spent the last year revamping health care policies, such as by recommending fewer vaccines for children and pulling out of the World Health Organization.

“While Donald Trump and (Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr.) undermine science, spread dangerous vaccine misinformation and put countless lives at risk, my administration is forging a different path — one that puts our people first,” Gov. JB Pritzker said in a news release Thursday. “With key insights from the (Illinois Immunization Advisory Committee), we’re endorsing clear, evidence-based immunization schedules to help keep Illinois families safe as the federal government chooses

Turn to Vaccines, Page 2

GOP rebuffs reforms, limits for ICE agents

Emboldened Dems insist they won’t vote to fund DHS without changes

By Mary Clare Jalonick
and Lisa Mascaro
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — Senate Majority Leader John Thune said Thursday that demands made by Democrats for new restrictions on federal immigration officers are “unrealistic” and warned that the Department of Homeland Security will shut down next week if they do not work with Republicans and the White House.

Democrats say they will not vote for a DHS spending bill when funding runs out unless there are changes at U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement and other federal law enforcement agencies in the wake of the fatal shootings of two protesters in Minneapolis last month.

The Democratic leaders, Sen. Chuck Schumer and Rep. Hakeem Jeffries, released an expanded list of 10 detailed proposals Wednesday night

Turn to Congress, Page 9

■ Trial for “Broadview Six” protesters is scheduled for May. **Chicagoland, Page 2**

INSIDE

Some parents not buying McMahon’s civics lesson



Education Secretary Linda McMahon addressed students at a private Christian high school on the Near West Side on Thursday, her latest stop on a national civics tour that

some have criticized as bringing partisan politics into schools. **Chicagoland, Page 3**



SELL, SELL, SELL: Bulls hit reset button with deadline deals. **Chicago Sports**

